from Germany through a combination of discrimination, legal pressure and controlled acts of violence. At points in the 1930s, the pressure on the Jews was even reduced (such as in the period of the 1936 Olympics) as they sought to limit negative international publicity.

What became known as the Holocaust commenced in mid-1941 and progressed in two different phases. To begin with, there were distinctions in how Jews were treated in different occupied territories. Within the occupied territories of the USSR, mass murder became the norm within days of the invasion and fused with the war against the Soviet partisans. This was mass killing of civilians as soon as possible after the German army had occupied a region. In Poland, the Jewish community was increasingly imprisoned in ghettos where starvation and brutality exacted a steady death toll. In Germany and Western Europe, the norm was increasingly exclusion from society and deportation to the east. However, even in Germany, the Nazis faced some constraints from public attitudes in terms of what was acceptable.

These relative distinctions broke down in early 1942 for several related reasons. The entry of the US into the war had removed any remaining fear of adverse international reaction. Civil and religious pressure had forced the suspension of a campaign of murder against Germans deemed to be mentally or physically unfit, thus freeing up ‘specialists’, who had already experimented with mass killing using poison gas, for other tasks. Finally, the regime was facing food shortages and was desperate to eliminate those it saw as surplus and undesirable.[30] This effectively removed the last constraints and led to the construction of the extermination camps in Poland and, by late 1944, the massacre of over 6 million European Jews.

In effect, the Nazi genocide actually progressed in stages and needed to test the degree of tolerance in wider society. Open mass murder only became the norm with the invasion of the Soviet Union. With that final barrier crossed, by 1942 sufficient sections of German society and the state were prepared to engage in the mass murder of Europe’s Jewish population. However, even at this stage it progressed unevenly. Satellite regimes such as Mussolini’s Italy and Horthy’s Hungary were anti-Semitic but not prepared to engage in the mass murder of their own citizens. In these two countries mass deportation and murder only started once these regimes fell. Equally, in some occupied countries, civil society continued to function as a brake on the Nazis.